The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Viktor Orban, **Hungary's** prime minister since 2010, conceded defeat in parliamentary elections. Despite years spent reshaping the electoral system to favour his illiberal Fidesz party, the centre-right Tisza party, led by **Peter Magyar**, was projected to win 138 of 199 seats with 99% of votes counted. That would give Tisza the two-thirds majority it needs to reshape the constitution, and to try to repair the rigged system.

The Pentagon said a blockade of the **Strait of Hormuz** would begin at 10am Eastern Time on Monday. After peace talks with Iran broke down over the weekend, Donald Trump posted on social media that the navy would clear the strait of mines, warning that "any Iranian who fires at us, or at peaceful vessels, will be BLOWN TO HELL!"

In response to Mr Trump's threat, **oil prices** rose by more than 7%, pushing Brent crude above $100 a barrel again on Monday. Most Asian markets closed down. Bourses in Europe also dropped when they opened, with the STOXX 600 falling by around 1%. Trading of S&P 500 futures suggests American stocks are set to fare similarly on opening.

Mr Trump insisted that the weekend's **negotiations** with Iran "went well" and that "most points were agreed to", except the "only point that really mattered, NUCLEAR". Earlier J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, who led the American delegation, suggested Iran had refused to make "an affirmative commitment" not to "seek a nuclear weapon". Iran's top negotiator accused the Americans of having "failed to gain the trust of the Iranian delegation".

Audi, a German carmaker, delivered 6% fewer vehicles in the first quarter of 2026 compared with a year earlier. A spokesman for Volkswagen, its parent company, said that Mr Trump's tariffs and a withdrawal of government subsidies for electric vehicles in China were largely responsible for the decline in sales. Volkswagen's shares have fallen by 15% this year so far.

An air strike by **Nigeria's** air force targeting Boko Haram militants reportedly killed more than 100 civilians at a market in the country's north-east. The air force said it had killed Islamist rebels in the area, and was investigating non-combatant casualties. More than 500 civilians have been killed in such strikes since 2017, according to the Associated Press.

Rory McIlroy won a second consecutive Masters, becoming the fourth golfer in history to do so. The Northern Irishman has now won six majors. On Sunday Mr McIlroy shot a 71 to finish on 12 under at Augusta National golf club—one stroke ahead of Scottie Scheffler, the world number one. Mr McIlroy said he planned to "celebrate to the fullest".

Figure of the day: 60%, the share of young Britons had some kind of post-secondary qualification in 2024. Read the full article.

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Strait to the brink

The risk of escalation is rising around the Strait of Hormuz. Iran has said any military vessel approaching the waterway would be “dealt with severely”. State media report that Iran is deploying troops to its southern coast, in what appears to be preparation for a potential American invasion. Donald Trump, meanwhile, has announced a blockade of the strait. Central Command, the Pentagon command that runs operations in the Middle East, said it would target all ships entering and exiting Iranian ports, allowing others to pass to and from other Gulf countries.

America’s president is under pressure to reopen the strait and calm energy markets. Rising fuel costs at home have dented his already-low approval ratings. But he seems unsure where things are heading. Asked whether oil and gas prices will fall before midterm elections in November, he replied: “I hope so. I mean, I think so. It could be the same or maybe a little bit higher.”

Photograph: Getty Images

Lebanon’s tight spot

After killing at least 300 people in air strikes on Lebanon on April 8th, Israel has agreed to limit its attacks on Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militia. Mr Trump had urged Israel to be more “low-key”. Beirut, Lebanon’s capital, is reportedly now off the list of targets, but Israel may strike elsewhere. Its troops remain in an 8km-deep strip on the Lebanese side of the border. Meanwhile, Hizbullah continues to attack Israeli towns with missiles and drones.

Israeli and Lebanese diplomats will meet in Washington on April 14th. Lebanon urgently wants to negotiate a ceasefire. Israel will not agree without assurances from the Lebanese government that it will disarm Hizbullah—a task the government would struggle to carry out even if the fighting stopped. Hizbullah and its Iranian patrons have threatened to foment a coup if the government tries. Stuck between Israel and Iran, Lebanon has little room to manoeuvre.

Photograph: Reuters

Goldman Sachs tees off first

Earnings season for America's big banks begins on Monday, when Goldman Sachs reports its first-quarter results. Though fewer mergers and acquisitions were completed during that period than in the same one last year, their value is greater than for any year since the first quarter of 2021, with transactions topping $1.2trn. Goldman, the biggest dealmaker on Wall Street, has been a prime beneficiary. Analysts expect it to report $17bn in revenue, a 12.9% year-on-year increase.

Many banks' share prices dipped in March as energy prices rose, software-firm valuations sank and worries about private credit grew. Goldman's did too, but has since recovered. Will Goldman and its peers reassure investors that these risks are under control? Last month the firm said it was optimistic that dealmaking would continue despite the volatility. Investors will want evidence that this confidence is justified.

Photograph: Reuters

Republicans' tough week in Congress

When America's Senate returns from a two-week break on Monday, Republicans will try to reopen the Department of Homeland Security. That is easier said than done. At almost two months, the partial government shutdown is the longest on record. Democrats refuse to back a funding bill unless it includes reforms to immigration-enforcement agencies. So the Republicans' leaders want to fund that separately, using an arcane procedure called "reconciliation" which requires only a simple majority. That will require clearing two high hurdles: only budgetary measures can be passed by reconciliation, and enough Republicans in the House of Representatives must be persuaded not to scupper the plan.

Iran could provide an unwelcome distraction. Last week Senate Democrats vowed to force a vote on whether to constrain Donald Trump's ability to wage war without congressional approval. The breakdown of peace talks at the weekend will give that renewed urgency. Republican leaders may struggle to walk and chew gum at the same time.

Photograph: Getty Images

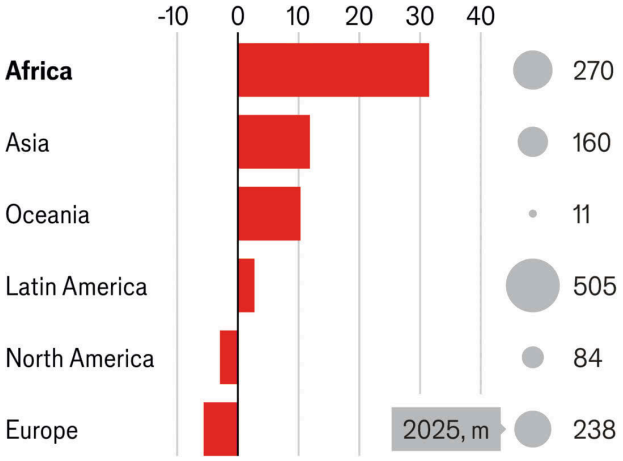
The pope finds a receptive audience in Africa

The papacy of Leo XIV, the first American pontiff, has had a rocky start. His pronouncements on climate change and migration, as well as his criticisms of America's war on Iran, have infuriated MAGA Catholics and Donald Trump—who on Sunday called Leo a "very liberal person" who was "weak" and "terrible".

So Leo's tour of four African countries, which starts on Monday in Algeria, should come as a welcome relief. Catholicism is growing faster in Africa than anywhere else. The continent could be home to as many as half the world's Catholics by 2066. The church is less polarising in Africa than elsewhere. It is widely seen as a champion of democracy, and is relatively untainted by the sexual-abuse scandals which have dogged it in the West. Leo is expected to use his first big overseas trip to deliver a message of peace and concern for the poor. Africa is sure to be receptive, even if America is not.

New Faithful

Catholic population, % change 2015-25



Source: World Christian Database

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which American film maker is known for documentary series on the US civil war, baseball and the Vietnam war?

How can you go out on a limb if you do not know your own tree?

Eudora Welty